



Privacy & Anonymity

They are not the same, know the difference

Imagine entering a railway station wearing a mask. People cannot immediately recognise your face, but they can still observe your height, clothes, luggage, companions, destination and payment method. If you remove the mask to show your ticket, your earlier movements may become easier to connect with your identity. Online privacy works similarly: hiding one identifier does not hide every other clue.

People often confuse privacy, anonymity and security. That confusion leads to unsafe decisions. Someone assumes an Incognito window makes them invisible. Another believes an encrypted chat hides who contacted whom. A third creates a fictional username but uses the same photograph and recovery number as a personal account. Each has gained one protection while mistakenly assuming they gained several.

Privacy means controlling exposure

Privacy is the ability to influence what information about you is collected, used, shared and retained. It is not the same as hiding everything. You can tell a hospital about a medical problem while expecting that information not to appear in an advertising database. You can share your location with a cab driver for one journey without wanting the application to retain a permanent record of your movements.

Do not merely ask, "Is this private?" Ask, "Private from whom, for what purpose and for how long?" NIST describes privacy risk in terms of problems people may experience because systems process data across its lifecycle, from collection to disposal. Privacy is therefore about context and control, and not just simply secrecy.